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The Christmas Box



ISSN 1544-1423

By Brian Weilert

I woke to the sound of nothing, knowing something important was at hand. My blurred mind fought for clarity in the early morning hours. My encrusted little eyes quickly darted to the left as I noticed an interruption to the darkness. Flashing lights. The doorway to my room blinked at me triggering the memory that it was Christmas morning. I was alone in my cold room. My scrawny eight year old body pulled the electric blanket up around my burgundy nose. The blanket itself had been bought at a garage sale minus the plug-in and as a result had never been introduced to an outlet. The thick cord serpentining through the interior teased me as to what it was capable of. I listened as the wind whistled through the hole of my single-paned window. Grey duct tape struggled to hold the cardboard in place. I could feel the whistle moving across my blanket and I started to shiver. I thought back to last summer when I had made the hole. Stacia, my ten year old sister, had held me down and tickled my ribs to the point where it was no longer funny, though I continued to laugh. When I was finally freed, I picked up the broken head of my blue Rock'em-Sock'em Robot and flung it with all my might; missing my sister, but not the window. Five months later and it still hadn't been fixed.

I reached up and rubbed the Sandman's last delivery from the corners of my eyes and looked across the room to gauge the distance to my clothes. I tried to psyche myself up to make the Arctic run. The heat in our trailer had been off for the past two weeks when the propane had ran out. My dad, Richard, didn't work much lately, which was cool. He and Mom spent all day at home with us. I was the only kid I knew that had not only one, but both parents around. All my friends had to go to a babysitter after school, I got to go home. On weekends, Dad and I would hang out in our underwear until noon watching cartoons. Sometimes he would even go down and play men at the creek with me. I knew for certain that I had the best Dad in the world. I cupped my hands over my mouth and nose and blew out hot air. It felt good so I did it three more times.

"Taylor? Taylor?" Stacia's voice meandered into the room.
During the flashes from the tree lights in the living room, I could see little puffs of smoke escaping from her lips as she spoke.

"What?" I whispered back. As if that was a formal invitation, she erupted into my room and scurried under my blanket. "Hey! Keep your cold feet off of me! You're freezing."

"So, you're warm."
We laid there together, quiet, enjoying each others body warmth.

Finally, I broke the silence. "You think Mom and Dad are up yet?"

"No stupid, they always wait. They want us to wake them up."
With that said I leapt from the bed and attacked a pair of sweats that had been hiding in the

corner of my room. My thin, pale body clad in Spiderman Underoos set a new world record for the snatch and return. I quickly put on my clothes while under the blanket. I earned an extra bonus as I discovered my socks from yesterday had taken refuge in the legs of the sweats.

As always, I would be sent down the hallway as a spy. My objective was to observe the living room and then report back to central headquarters, my sister. I slid from the bed and maneuvered the obstacles of wayward toys during the flashes of light. Stop, go, stop, go. My hiccupped movements slowly progressed me towards the target. After an eternal five minutes of army crawling I reached my destination. I lay flat on my belly, just at the end of the hall, staring towards the tree. Flash, one single box. Flash, the same box as last year. Flash, the Santa paper with the gold bow. I felt a collision of feelings inside me that I really didn't understand. I was filled with the excitement of Christmas morning, the nerves twisting my empty stomach, but at the same time this year I felt something different. I put my head down on the thick, hominy-colored shag carpet to think. A single strand of the carpet wriggled into the corner of my mouth and I bit down tasting the dirt, feeling the grit in my teeth. I was cold, hungry and confused. The feeling I couldn't place had consumed me. Although, the emotion was a stranger to me, I did know that my happiness was damaged by it somehow. I stayed in that position until my thoughts were interrupted by the whisper scream of my sister.

"Hey, are you dead down there?"

I turned and crawled back down the hall to report. She was still tucked up under the blanket.

"You ready?" I asked my sister. Stacia gave me a smile accompanied with a nod and we exploded down the hallway. The whole trailer shook under our thunderous steps. We took a sharp left before reaching the living room and jumped on top of the two lumps we presumed were our parents. My dad shifted beneath the blanket before encompassing both my sister and I into his quilted grasp. From beneath the blanket, his tired smiling face emerged and swiftly dug into my neck making grunting noises. I pushed my head hard into the cactus prickles of his whiskers in an effort to protect my tender neck from the onslaught of the bear-hug. Goose bumps, like hyper-sensitive little fingers, sprung up on my arms and legs sending my body into nerve overload. I screamed like a girl. The dog-whistle pitch mainlined into my father's ear canal ended the barrage almost immediately.

"Damn, boy you sound like your sister. Better check to see if you still have your twig and giggle-berries." With that, my father started to pinch at the inner parts of my thighs in feign attempts to check my groin. I both love and hate to be tickled. My spastic legs flailed about in a blur. Winded, my dad stopped. "You kids ready?" he puffed, frosted smoke escaping his dry cracked lips. As he spoke I recognized the all too familiar odor of *Coors* beer. He had let me have a sip last summer, I didn't even like the smell of it then, and I hated the smell of it now.

As one, enveloped in our parent's comforter, we moved to the living room, to the tree. My eyes immediately fell to the isolated worn single present. The sight of this had brought immense pleasure in the past, but this year that ache in my stomach arose again. My dad must have sensed that something was off as our eyes met his smile disappeared. At that moment my dad looked as a man who had been caught doing something wrong. A thief discovered. He looked old and tired. It frightened me. A pause, and his smile resumed but this time it wasn't real. It was forced. We pulled the present to the center of the living room and sat Indian style around the present and held hands. My mother prayed the short prayer that was made up but always contained the same information.

"God, thank you for giving us your child so that we all may enter your kingdom. Thank you for our family and this day. Let us always remember that all that is done is your will and the reasons, though unknown to us, have purpose. Amen."

I always found strength in my mother's words. When we were cold or hungry I knew it was all in God's plan. When kids made fun of my home and my dad I knew God was testing my patience holding great things for my future. I use to dream he was making me tough and wise so when I grew up I could be a super hero.

Mother was always the first to open the present. She slowly lifted the lid and sat it aside. She leaned over and when her face came up it was an expression of pure ecstasy. "You shouldn't have." Her hands went into the empty box as she pantomimed pulling out a large garment. "Where did you get the money? Is it real mink?" She stood, putting on the coat, swirling around and laughing. My sister too was laughing. I tried, I really did but I could only manage a fake smile. An event that once had brought me great pleasure now caused me to be embarrassed by my mother's antics. I looked at my father. He was not watching my mother but me. His sad eyes revealed that he knew that I knew. The feeling in my stomach had worked itself into an emotional collage of anger, deceit, and shame. My stare caused my father to turn away and give my mother a forced sickening weak laugh. My mother sat down with her arms wrapped about her chest as she was holding her new mink coat tight. She then reached out and placed the lid back on the box and pushed it towards my sister. Stacia's hands appeared from under the comforter and pulled the lid from the box. "Mom? Dad? How did you know?" Her smile lit up the room. Even I, for a moment was once again caught up in the act. "If this is what I think it is this will be the coolest gift anyone has ever given me." Stacia reached into the box and withdrew an invisible present that sat in the palm of her hand. I was leaning forward, dying to know what it was. With her free hand she reached over an lifted the cover of the object in her palm. "It is! Are those real diamonds?" She snatched the ring from it holder and place it on her finger. She held her hand out to me. "Have you ever seen anything more stunning?" I looked down at her hand and told her it was blinding me. She giggled. Still beaming, she put the lid on the box and pushed it in front of me. A moment, an eternity I sat there with that box in front of me. I heard encouragements from my mother and sister to open it up but I really didn't hear what they said. A moment, an eternity. I looked up at my father. Our eyes met for the third time that morning. A moment, an eternity.

"I can't." were the only words I could manage. Tears were running from the corners of my father's eyes. I began to cry. My father stood and disappeared into the bedroom. A moment, an eternity. The gunshot echoing through the trailer was deafening. The three of us sat there in silence, ears ringing, smoke escaping with each breath. A moment, an eternity. My mother's scream crippled me. She ran to the bedroom and I hear wails of pain so intense that I became sick. My sister sprinted to the room and her high pitched scream join my mother's cry. I sat in the living room unable to move with the present between my legs.

A tugging at my pajama top pulls me back to the here and now. My eight year old son Richey is pleading with me to open the box." Your presents are always the best dad. What did you get this year?" I looked up to see my wife and three children before me. The light cast from the fireplace dancing shadows across their faces. Around us was warmth and love. Piles of presents yet to be opened where stretched out behind them. "Open it up dad."

Between my legs sat the same box, with the same Santa paper and gold bow. Thirty years. My hands lifted the lid. I reached inside the empty box and my eyes lit up. "How did you know

I wanted this? I almost asked you to get me one but figured there was no way."

What is it daddy, what is it?" Richey yelled.

My hands slowly lifted from the box holding something in my palms.

"What is it daddy!"

"It is God's plan for me. It is the purpose behind everything from my past. It is the answer."

Richey looked confused. My head lifted to meet my wife's eyes. She was crying. I felt a tickle on my cheek. I too was crying. All those years of guilt for the death of my father were erased as I looked at my family. I knew why I had lived the life I lived. In my children's eyes, I was a super hero. I sat there feeling the flood of relief flow from my soul. A moment, an eternity.

Tibetan Treefrog Publishing
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